

SALES DOMAIN

Order Shipment

Knowledge Base & Operations Reference

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1. Overview of Order Shipment

Order shipment is the process of physically moving goods from the seller's warehouse or fulfilment centre to the customer's delivery address. It encompasses the entire logistics chain: order picking, quality check, packing, label generation, carrier handoff, in-transit tracking, last-mile delivery, and proof of delivery (POD) collection.

Efficient shipment management is a critical competitive differentiator. Customers expect fast, transparent, and reliable delivery. This document provides comprehensive guidance on every aspect of the shipment lifecycle, carrier partnerships, tracking systems, delivery exceptions, international shipping, and customer communication protocols.

1.1 Shipment Lifecycle Stages

Stage	Description
Order Confirmed	Payment cleared; order enters the fulfilment queue.
Processing	OMS transmits order details to Warehouse Management System (WMS).
Picking	Warehouse staff or robotic systems locate and retrieve items.
Quality Check	Items inspected for damage, correct variant, and completeness.
Packing	Items packed per category guidelines (fragile, oversized, temperature-sensitive).
Label Generation	Shipping label with carrier barcode, AWB number, and address printed.
Carrier Handoff	Parcel handed to carrier; electronic manifest uploaded.
In Transit	Parcel scanned at carrier hubs; tracking events generated.
Out for Delivery	Last-mile agent loads parcel; customer notified.
Delivered	POD captured (signature, photo, OTP). Order closed.
Exceptions	Failed delivery attempts, returns to origin, lost or damaged in transit.

2. Shipping Methods and Service Levels

2.1 Standard Domestic Shipping Options

Service	Est. Delivery	Cost	Best For	Tracking
Same-Day	Same day (order before 11 AM)	Premium	Urgent, local orders	Real-time GPS
Next-Day Express	Next business day	High	Time-sensitive, high value	Full milestones

Service	Est. Delivery	Cost	Best For	Tracking
2-Day Express	2 business days	Moderate-High	Electronics, fashion	Full milestones
Standard (3–5d)	3–5 business days	Low-Moderate	Everyday items	Hub-level
Economy (5–7d)	5–7 business days	Low	Low-priority, heavy items	Pickup & delivery
Scheduled Delivery	Customer-chosen date/slot	Moderate	Furniture, appliances	SMS slot reminders
Click & Collect	Ready within 2–4 hours	Free	Local store pickup	Ready notification

2.2 International Shipping Options

International orders involve customs documentation, duties and taxes, restricted item lists, and longer transit times. The following tiers are available:

Service Tier	Transit Time	Customs Handling	Tracking Depth
International Priority	3–5 business days	Carrier-assisted DDP	End-to-end including customs milestones
International Economy	7–14 business days	Receiver handles import (DAP)	Origin to destination country
International Standard	10–21 business days	Postal service integration	Limited — origin and arrival only
B2B Freight (Air)	2–4 business days	Full customs brokerage	Detailed freight tracking
B2B Freight (Sea)	15–45 days	Full customs brokerage	Container-level tracking

2.3 Free Shipping Thresholds

- Domestic orders above \$35 (or local currency equivalent) qualify for free standard shipping.
- Premium members (loyalty tier Gold and above) receive free shipping on all orders.
- Certain promotional campaigns may temporarily lower or remove the threshold.
- Oversized items, special-handling items, and international orders are excluded.
- Click & Collect is always free regardless of order value.

3. Carrier Partners and Selection Logic

3.1 Primary Carrier Partners

The company maintains contracts with multiple carriers for geographic coverage, service redundancy, and competitive pricing. Carrier selection is automated by the Shipping Optimisation Engine (SOE) based on delivery speed, cost, and performance score for the destination pin code.

Carrier	Coverage	Strengths	SLA Performance
FedEx	Domestic + 220 countries	Express, high-value, temperature-controlled	99.1% on-time
UPS	Domestic + 200 countries	B2B freight, large parcels	98.7% on-time
DHL Express	International priority	Global customs expertise	98.5% on-time
USPS / Royal Mail	Domestic + postal network	Economy, remote area coverage	96.2% on-time
Regional Partner	Tier-2/3 cities, rural	Last-mile rural coverage	94.8% on-time
Same-Day Partner	Metro cities only	2-hour delivery windows	97.3% on-time

3.2 Carrier Selection Logic (SOE Parameters)

- Destination pin code / zip code coverage by each carrier
- Selected service level (same-day, next-day, standard, economy)
- Parcel dimensions and weight for rate calculation
- Carrier performance score for the destination zone (rolling 30-day SLA data)
- Current carrier capacity and peak-season surcharges
- Special handling requirements (fragile, hazmat, temperature-sensitive)
- Customer's loyalty tier — premium customers routed to higher-performing carriers

4. Shipment Tracking and Visibility

4.1 Tracking Methods Available to Customers

Order Tracking Page: Accessible via My Orders in the app or website. Shows real-time status with a visual timeline. No login required when using the tracking link.

SMS Notifications: Automated SMS at key milestones: Dispatched, Out for Delivery, Delivered. Managed via notification settings.

Email Notifications: Tracking link sent at dispatch. Delivery confirmation email with POD details after successful delivery.

WhatsApp Updates: For opted-in customers, real-time WhatsApp messages at each tracking milestone.

Carrier Website: Customers can track directly using the AWB number provided in the dispatch notification.

AI Chatbot: Customers can ask 'Where is my order?' and receive an instant natural-language status update.

4.2 Tracking Status Definitions

Status Code	Display Text	Meaning
CONFIRMED	Order Confirmed	Order placed and payment verified.
PROCESSING	Being Prepared	Warehouse picking and packing in progress.
DISPATCHED	Shipped	Parcel handed to carrier; AWB number generated.
IN_TRANSIT	On Its Way	Parcel moving through the carrier network.
AT_HUB	At Sorting Facility	Parcel is at a carrier sorting or distribution hub.
OUT_FOR_DEL	Out for Delivery	Last-mile agent has the parcel; delivery expected today.
DELIVERED	Delivered	POD captured (signature, photo, or OTP). Order complete.
DEL_ATTEMPT	Delivery Attempted	Delivery tried but failed; reattempt scheduled.
RTO_INIT	Returning to Seller	Parcel returning to warehouse after failed delivery attempts.
RTO_DELIVERED	Returned to Warehouse	Parcel received back at origin; refund process initiated.
LOST	Lost in Transit	Carrier has confirmed the parcel cannot be located.
DAMAGED	Damaged in Transit	Parcel reported as damaged; claim investigation initiated.

5. Delivery Operations and Exceptions

5.1 Delivery Attempt Policy

Carriers are instructed to make up to three delivery attempts before initiating return to origin (RTO).

Attempt	Timing	Action if Failed
1st Attempt	As scheduled / route-optimized	Customer notified via SMS and email; 2nd attempt scheduled for next business day.
2nd Attempt	Next business day	Customer contacted to arrange a preferred delivery time or alternate address.
3rd Attempt	48 hours after 2nd attempt	If failed, parcel held for 24 hours, then RTO initiated automatically.

5.2 Delivery Exception Types and Resolutions

Customer Not Available: SMS/call sent to reschedule. Parcel held at carrier facility for 48 hours. Customer can self-schedule via the tracking portal.

Incorrect / Incomplete Address: Support contacts customer for address correction. Carrier re-routes if parcel is still in transit. Address correction fee may apply post-dispatch.

Access Restriction: Carrier notes access code requirement. Customer contacted for building access information or an alternative delivery point.

Customer Refused Delivery: Treated as a voluntary return. Refund processed upon warehouse receipt. Reason captured for seller analytics.

Lost in Transit: Initiated after 3 days beyond expected delivery with no scan event. Carrier investigation opens (SLA: 5–10 business days). Replacement or full refund offered.

Damaged in Transit: Customer reports damage at delivery or within 48 hours. Photo evidence requested. Replacement dispatched within 2 business days or refund processed.

Weather / Natural Disaster Delay: Proactive notification with revised ETA. No penalty to the customer. Force majeure clauses protect carrier SLA.

Customs Hold (International): Customer or customs broker contacted for additional documentation. Duties and taxes may need to be paid before customs release.

6. International Shipping — Customs and Compliance

6.1 Required Customs Documentation

- Commercial Invoice: Lists item descriptions, quantities, values, and HS (Harmonized System) codes.
- Packing List: Details physical contents of each package including dimensions and weight.
- Certificate of Origin: Declares where goods were manufactured (required for some trade agreements).
- Export Licence: Required for controlled goods (certain electronics, chemicals).
- Dangerous Goods Declaration (DGD): Mandatory for hazardous materials per IATA regulations.
- Phytosanitary Certificate: Required for plant-based products entering certain countries.

6.2 Duties and Taxes — Incoterms

Import duties are determined by the destination country's customs authority based on HS code, declared value, and applicable trade agreements.

DDP – Delivered Duty Paid: Seller pays all duties and taxes. Customer receives goods with no additional charges. Price at checkout includes estimated duties. Recommended for a premium customer experience.

DAP – Delivered at Place: Customer pays import duties upon delivery or customs clearance. Used for economy international shipping. Customer is informed at checkout.

Note: For DDP shipments, if actual duties exceed the estimated amount collected at checkout, the company absorbs the difference. Customers are never asked for additional payment after placing a DDP order.

6.3 Prohibited and Restricted Items (International)

- Flammable liquids and compressed gases (aerosols, lighter fuel, perfumes above 100 ml by air)
- Standalone lithium batteries (embedded batteries permitted with restrictions)
- Firearms, ammunition, and weapon components
- Counterfeit or pirated goods

- Perishables without appropriate temperature packaging and customs clearance
- Currency, coins, and negotiable instruments
- Prescription medicines (restrictions vary by destination country)
- Certain food products restricted by the destination country's agricultural authority

7. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: How do I track my shipment?

A: You can track via: (1) 'My Orders' in the app or website → click order → Track Order; (2) The tracking link in your dispatch confirmation email; (3) The carrier's website using the AWB number; or (4) Ask the AI chatbot 'Where is my order?'

Q: What is the expected delivery time for my order?

A: Delivery time depends on your selected method and location. Standard domestic: 3–5 business days. Express: 1–2 business days. Same-day available in select metro areas for orders placed before 11 AM. International: 3 to 21+ business days depending on destination.

Q: My order shows 'Out for Delivery' but wasn't delivered today. What happened?

A: Route delays, traffic, or high delivery volume may delay your order to the next day. You'll receive a notification confirming the reattempt. If the status persists for more than 2 days, contact support so we can investigate with the carrier.

Q: Can I change my delivery address after the order has shipped?

A: Possible only if the parcel hasn't reached the destination city hub. Contact support immediately with your Order ID. An address correction fee of \$3–\$5 may apply. Changes to international shipments in customs cannot be made.

Q: What happens if I miss all three delivery attempts?

A: The parcel is held at the carrier's facility or nearest pickup point for 48 hours. After this hold, the parcel returns to our warehouse and a refund is processed within 7–14 business days of warehouse receipt.

Q: My package arrived damaged. What should I do?

A: Do not discard the packaging. Photograph the outer packaging, inner packaging, and damaged item. Contact support within 48 hours with your Order ID and photos. A replacement will be dispatched within 2 business days, or a full refund provided if out of stock.

Q: Do you ship to PO Boxes?

A: Standard and economy services support PO Box delivery via postal carrier. Express and same-day services require a physical street address. International express carriers (FedEx, DHL) do not deliver to PO Boxes.

Q: Why is my order stuck at a sorting facility for multiple days?

A: Parcels may be held due to adverse weather, peak-season volume surges, or a customs hold. Check the tracking page for the latest event. If there is no update for more than 3 business days, contact support to open a carrier trace request.

Q: What is a 'Return to Origin' (RTO) and will I get a refund?

A: RTO occurs when a parcel cannot be delivered and is returned to our warehouse—after exhausted delivery attempts, customer refusal, or an undeliverable address. Once received back, a full refund is processed within 7–14 business days to your original payment method.

Q: Do I need to pay customs duties for international orders?

A: It depends on the term shown at checkout. 'DDP (Duties Paid)' means all customs charges are included in your total—nothing extra to pay. 'DAP' means you are responsible for paying import duties to the customs authority in your country before or at delivery.

Q: Can I reschedule my delivery to a specific time slot?

A: Yes, for scheduled delivery service (large items, appliances) and in metro areas with same-day partners. Use 'Manage Delivery' on the tracking page to choose a date and 2-hour slot. Standard parcel carriers may offer a preferred date but not a specific time window.

Q: What is the maximum parcel weight and size for standard shipping?

A: Standard domestic: up to 30 kg, maximum 120 × 60 × 60 cm. Items exceeding these are classified as freight and routed via the B2B freight service. International parcel limits vary by carrier — check the shipping calculator at checkout.

8. Shipment KPIs and Performance Benchmarks

KPI	Definition	Target
On-Time Delivery (OTD)	% of orders delivered within promised window	> 97%
First Attempt Del. Rate	% delivered successfully on the first attempt	> 88%
RTO Rate	% of shipments returned to origin	< 4%
Lost in Transit Rate	% of shipments confirmed lost	< 0.1%
Damage Rate	% of shipments with damage reported at delivery	< 0.3%
Avg Dispatch Time	Time from order confirmation to carrier handoff	< 18 hrs
Tracking Update Freq.	Avg interval between tracking scan events	< 6 hrs
Shipment CSAT	Post-delivery survey score	> 4.4 / 5
Exception Resolution SLA	% of delivery exceptions resolved within 48 hours	> 92%

This document is reviewed quarterly. Contact logistics@company.com for updates. Last reviewed: Q4 2024.